



Indian Ocean

THE THIRD LARGEST ocean in the world, the Indian Ocean is bounded by Africa, Asia, Australasia, and the Southern Ocean. The ocean contains some 5,000 islands. Madagascar and Sri Lanka are large, but most of the islands are small and ringed by coral reefs. The people of the Maldives have very mixed origins, incorporating Indian, Sinhalese, Arab, and African heritage, while two-thirds of those living on Mauritius are Indian immigrants and their descendents. Altogether, about one-fifth of the world's population live on this ocean's warm shores. Those along the northern coasts are often threatened by monsoon rain and tropical storms, which can cause severe flooding.

CORAL ISLANDS

Coral is a living organism formed in warm water by tiny sea creatures known as polyps. These creatures build limestone skeletons around themselves, which accumulate over thousands of years. As sea levels change, this coral can be exposed as low-lying islands or submerged as reefs.



THE SEYCHELLES

The Seychelles consists of around 155 islands—some are coral islands while others are mountainous and made of granite. Most Seychellois people are Creoles—people of mixed African, Asian, and European ancestry. There are also small Chinese and Indian communities.



Market on the largest Seychelles island, Mahé



ENVIRONMENT

Beautiful shells are for sale on this beach in South Africa. If the trader only collects empty shells, no harm is done, but in many parts of the world, dealers hunt live shellfish, sea turtles, and rare species of starfish and sea urchins. Nations such as the Maldives take great care to protect their environment.

LIMITED TOURISM

The tropical climate, sandy beaches, beautiful coral reefs, and abundant marine life make both the Seychelles and the Maldives ideal tourist destinations. These same features also make them extremely attractive to scuba divers. However, the fragile environment of both island nations means that they have deliberately tried to make them exclusive, attracting only limited numbers of wealthy visitors, instead of pursuing mass tourism.



THE MALDIVES

The Maldives is a low-lying archipelago of 1,190 small, coral islands, of which 200 are inhabited. The main industries are fishing—still carried out by traditional pole-and-line methods to conserve stocks—and tourism. Holiday resorts are on separate islands to those inhabited by the locals, so as not to disturb the Maldivians' traditional Muslim lifestyles.

